RIVER RAFTING TIME

Harak Rawat is only one name in Uttarakhand's political flotsam. Both BJP and Congress have their hands full with rebellion

BY ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

On Sunday, January 16, when the BJP's Uttarakhand core group sat with party chief J.P. Nadda at his Delhi residence, no one in the room could miss the glaringly conspicuous absence: that of the petulant Harak Singh Rawat, state forest minister. Everyone knew he had been yo-yoing in his loyalties for a week or two—they also knew he was in Delhi at that precise moment. It was all too intolerable for the party leadership, which had already had enough of Harak's tantrums. Then and there, a decision was made to sack him from the Pushkar Dhami cabinet and expel him from the party too for good measure.

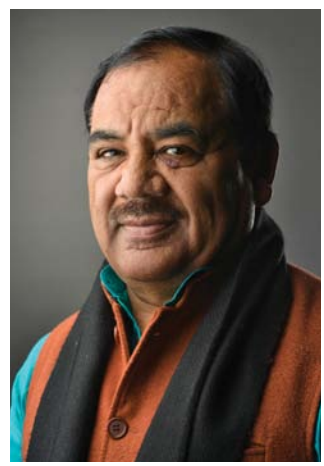
Harak had spent his Sunday meeting his old bosses in the Congress in the Capital...hard-selling his idea of a good bargain. That naturally entails a ticket for himself. Not from his present seat, Kotdwar, in the green foothills of southeastern Uttarakhand, but 10,000 feet higher up...from high-prestige Kedarnath! That isn't all. As a package deal, Harak also wants a ticket for his daughter-in-law—Anukriti Gusain, a former Miss India—from Lansdowne, the pretty cantonment town next door to Kotdwar well-known to weekend tourists from Delhi.

Rawat is not the only one to indulge in a spot of political tourism in this poll season. Before him, state transport minister Yashpal Arya too had quit the Dhami cabinet to return to the Congress. In 2016, this very duo had made the pleasant group trek to Camp BJP, in the company of the likes of ex-CM Vijay Bahuguna and Amrita Rawat 'Mata Ji', who was herself only following her godman-cum-politician husband Satpal Maharaj, an earlier emigre. That episode of widespread dissension against then CM Harish Rawat was a major prelude to the Congress losing in 2017. Harish hasn't forgotten.

That's why Harak's move disturbs the air everywhere. His exit does no particular good to a dissension-ridden BJP, besides removing one malcontent. But the weather forecast for the Congress is equally inclement. Harak's prospective entry splits the party into two deeply divided camps. Harish is vehemently opposed to him; his bete noire, LoP Pritam Singh, is lobbying hard with the high command to veto Rawat.

The spectre of rebellion has both sides fairly spooked. The BJP, which hasn't exactly created a sense of solidity with its three CMs in five years, has decided to back the incumbent. Its whole campaign is being evolved around Dhami and his relative youth: he's 46. This means many grizzled veterans among its existing 57 legislators—in a house of 70—will be denied tickets. A top leader told India Today that at least 26 sitting MLAs may have to be replaced. Many of them, sensing the winds, are in touch with the Congress.

The GOP is no Garden of Eden either. After the passing of N.D. Tiwari and his protege Indrani Hridayesh, Pritam has taken over duties at the anti-Harish Rawat group. A temporary truce had been effected between the two, till Rahul Gandhi's return from vacation in mid-January. Rahul duly okayed Harak's entry. But as we go to press on Thursday morning, Harish had not relented.







SPINNING ROULETTE Clockwise from left: Harak Rawat, Satpal Maharaj, Yashpal Arya

In the last six months, a series of decisions have gone against Harish, still the tallest Congress leader here. The high command has persistently parried his demand that he be declared the CM candidate again. Nor are his people being accommodated as district PCC chiefs. As December wound to a close, Harish had even threatened to retire from active politics—the looming re-entry of Harak being the proximate cause. He was somehow mollifed, but with no clear overlordship. He and Pritam still make an unstable two-horse chariot.

Both camps have prepared their own list of candidates for all 70 seats. The entry of turncoats feeds right into this. Pritam is trying to consolidate ex-Congressmen who had quit owing to differences with Harish. It was he who facilitated the return, in November, of Yashpal Arya and his MLA son Sanjiv Arya. Now all eyes are on Satpal Maharaj—who's a close relative of Harak. Maharaj, 70, refutes all loose talk but his move may hinge on whether he—and wife Amrita—get tickets. The chances of heartburn there are high, given the BJP's one-family-one-ticket rule. There's a reverse flow of Congress rebels too, but the headwaters are still circling around in uncertain eddies. ■